Variants & shelved rules

Everything not in the base game, kept in one place

None of these are part of Blink. Some were in earlier versions and were retired; some were designed and simulated but never adopted. They are written out properly so that a decision can be revisited later without reconstructing it from memory.

Badges say how much is known: RETIRED was once a base rule · SIMULATED measured, never played · UNTESTED written only. Add one at a time, and only after the base game is familiar. The **Wasteland & Disaster** and **Trade** modules are larger and live in their own documents.

01 Pattern placement RETIRED IN V0.21

The spatial heart of Blink up to v0.20: a meld did not just decide *how many* cards you spent, it decided *what shape* your civilization took. This is the single biggest rule the game has ever dropped, and the one most worth being able to put back.

Instead of spending each card independently (§06), a meld lands as a pattern — one cell per card, resolved as a single piece. Three rules govern it:

- **Connected.** The cells of a piece touch each other, and at least one sits on — or next to — a tile you already occupy. A straight or a single set is one piece. A **two-set meld** (two pair, full house) lands as **two clusters**, each touching your civilization on its own; they need not touch each other, and you choose where each goes.
- **In rank order.** A straight is walked from its lowest rank to its highest. The order is fixed; the direction of each step is not — a straight of three is any three connected cells you can walk in rank order. A line, a chevron, a bend, a curl around a mountain.
- **Suit matches terrain.** Each card acts on a cell whose terrain matches its suit.

Each cell then does one of the four things a card can do — settle, explore, attack, or take gold. A cell whose terrain does not match its card simply **takes gold** and stays empty; the rest of the pattern still lands.

Legality is judged once, when you begin placing the meld. A tile you lay with one card does not open a space for a later card of the same meld — you work from the map as you found it.

Shift. A settle may take a unit already on the map, from any tile connected to your population, instead of one from the reserve. Free, but it grows nothing.

Swept off the map. With no units on the map at the start of your map phase, the pattern is exempt from the connection rule: place it on any unoccupied tiles matching its suits, anywhere.

WHAT IT BUYS, IN ONE LINE

A straight of four must walk four connected, terrain-matching cells in rank order. That constraint is the whole spatial game — the map stops being a list of legal squares and becomes a route you have to find.

WHY IT WAS RETIRED, AND THE CASE FOR PUTTING IT BACK

It was cut for **simplification**: the pattern rules were the largest single block in the rulebook, and the tight gold economy meant strong play cashed cards constantly — which broke patterns up anyway. It was also hard to justify thematically: a civilization does not expand in poker shapes.

The cost is that **meld shape no longer reaches the table**. Under v0.21 a straight of four and a quadruple do exactly the same work — four things done — so the five tiers of meld diagrams describe a distinction with no consequence. If v0.21 playtests as flat, this is the first thing to try restoring, possibly only at the larger melds.

Note that this variant also restores **shift**, which the base game replaced with free moves. Running both is untested and probably too much movement.

02 Population limits that grow with your board

SIMULATED

In the base game a terrain holds the same number all game — Plains 3, Forest 2, Ocean 1, Mountain 1. This variant makes the limits climb with your band, so the player board teaches you what your civilization can now support.

Population limits are printed per band, and the limit that applies to a tile is its owner's. Two players may legally stack the same terrain differently.

BAND	PLAINS	FOREST	OCEAN	MOUNTAIN
Founding	2	1	1	1
Growth	2	2	1	1
Expansion	3	2	1	1
Empire	3	3	2	2

Mountain and Ocean stay low throughout: hostile ground never becomes comfortable.

If starvation drops your band, your cities shed the difference. After you return units for missing food, every tile of yours holding more than your *new* limit sends the surplus back to the reserve. Famine hits the crowded places first.

Those returned units refill your reserve, which can drop your band again — repeat until no stack is over its limit. Only **starvation** culls: units lost in combat lower your band without emptying your cities, so a stack can sit above your current limit until the next famine.

Wider variant — flat start, wide Empire SIMULATED

Founding **1/1/1/1**, Growth 2/2/1/1, Expansion 3/2/1/1, Empire **4/3/2/2**. A stronger arc: every terrain holds exactly one at the start, and Empire opens everything. Measurably more runaway — see below.

DESIGNER'S NOTES — 40 GAMES, 3 PLAYERS, IDENTICAL SEEDS

	BASE (FIXED)	WIDER	THE TABLE ABOVE
units per occupied tile	1.23	1.37	1.30
leader minus last place	15.8	19.5	17.1
leader's units on map	10.9	12.9	11.9
last place's units	5.6	5.6	5.8
rounds · mean score · kills	unchanged within noise		

The whole benefit goes to whoever is already ahead. The leader gains up to two units; last place gains none — reaching Empire is what unlocks the wide limits, so the player who got there first is the only one who banks them. The final gap widens 23% under the wider ladder, 8% under the gentler one.

The flat start does more work than the wide end. Climbing to Empire takes most of the game, so the generous limits exist only for the last few rounds. Stacking rises, but the map is still mostly one unit per tile.

Small bonus: the twentieth-unit end trigger — which never fires in the base game under skilled play — fires in 4 games of 40 with either ladder, because stacking gives late units somewhere to go.

The famine cull is a rule for a situation that does not arise. Across 20 games with the bot's safety valves deliberately switched off, starvation returned **0.1 units per game** and the cull never fired once, let alone cascaded. Food costs roughly 13 gold a game against 47 earned — a real tax, but never an unpayable one. The rule is correct and closes a genuine hole; it is also, at these numbers, dormant.

Neither ladder is an improvement on the numbers alone. The case for them is *tactile*: a board that visibly grants you more room as you grow. That is exactly the kind of thing a simulation cannot score and a table can.

03 Dock the losers a card RETIRED IN V0.21

How the trick paid out until v0.21, and the reason it changed. Kept because the rule contains a subtlety that is easy to lose sight of.

The trick winner spends every card of their meld. Everyone else spends one card fewer than they played, and takes 1 gold for the card they had to leave out — their choice which.

Nobody gets an extra card, and the trick's last place is not singled out.

WHY IT WAS REPLACED

It asks every player to remember a number. "How many may I use this round?" is a question the current rule never poses.

It throws a card away against its owner's wishes every round, for every non-winner. Roughly a quarter more happens on the map once that stops.

It produced the worst score floor of any structure measured, at every player count: last place finished on 24.1 / 14.6 / 12.6 at two, three and four players, against 27.8 / 19.0 / 15.1 under the rule that replaced it. Those differences sit outside their confidence intervals; the gap differences between structures do not.

Its headline economy number was inflated. It showed the highest share of cards turned to gold — 47–50% — but part of that was the compulsory docked card. Under the current rule every coin is chosen, and the genuine rate is about a third.

The subtlety worth remembering: the coin paid for the docked card was an unconditional subsidy to whoever lost most tricks — a rubber band disguised as a penalty. Any replacement has to put that band back somewhere, which is exactly what the coin to last place does.

IF YOU WANT TO A/B IT AT THE TABLE

Play one game each way. The number to bring back is not who won — it is whether anyone had to ask how many cards they were allowed to use.

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04 Combination melds SIMULATED

Four- and five-card melds are rare in practice: the material seldom lines up. This lets smaller melds join forces.

You may combine two or more multi-card melds (sets and/or straights) into one *combination meld*:

- Every component must be a valid meld of **at least two cards**. Single cards may never be part of a combination.
- Each card belongs to exactly one component; the total must fit your meld limit.
- Trick score and tie-breaks work exactly as normal.

With pattern placement (§01): each component is placed separately, as its own piece. *In the base game:* a combination changes nothing about placement — it only lets you play more cards at once.

EXAMPLE

The pair *4 Plains + 4 Forest* with the straight *7-8-9 Forest* is a five-card meld scoring 32.

DESIGNER'S NOTES — MEASURED UNDER V0.20 PATTERN RULES

Five-card melds went from 0.65 to 1.43 per game at three players (+119%) and 0.55 to 1.68 at four (+205%); combinations settled at 12% of everything played. The game did **not** speed up — the end trigger is placing units, and combinations only batch placements. Straights were partly absorbed (45%→37% of melds) and singles rose slightly, so the distribution polarised.

These numbers predate v0.21 and were measured with patterns on the map. Under the base game the placement objection disappears entirely, which makes this variant both safer and less interesting — it becomes purely "play more cards at once".

Sub-variant — connected combinations UNTESTED

Only meaningful alongside pattern placement (§01): all components must together form one connected group on the map, restoring the placement discipline a 2+2 split would otherwise sidestep.

05 Super melds RETIRED

Part of Blink before v0.20, removed to streamline the meld vocabulary.

A super meld is any overlapping combination of melds — one card may belong to several components at once. Each component must be valid on its own, and both the meld limit and the trick score count each **physical card once**.

EXAMPLE

9 Plains, 9 Forest, 10 Forest: the 9 of Forest belongs to both the set 9+9 and the straight 9-10. Three cards, meld score 28.

DESIGNER'S NOTES

Removed on publisher feedback: spotting and verifying overlaps slows the trick for little gain, since each card still counts once. Not recommended together with combination melds — they cover the same ground, and combinations are simpler.

06 Friends of 10s RETIRED

An extra two-card meld from earlier versions, cut for simplicity.

Two cards of any suits whose ranks sum to exactly 10, 20 or 30 form a valid meld — 1+9, 2+8, 3+7, 4+6, 11+9, 12+8, 11+19, and so on.

DESIGNER'S NOTES

Gives low ranks a late-game purpose and creates cross-suit pairs that sets and straights cannot. Cut because it adds an arithmetic check to every hand evaluation. Effect on balance never measured.

07 Awakenings — one terrain power per terrain, per game PROPOSAL · UNTESTED

Four moments in a game where the ground you hold does something for you. Each terrain grants one power, once per game, and its strength is whatever you have standing on that terrain at the moment you use it. Mountains raise an army, forests think, plains breed, and the sea finds new land.

Once per game, for each terrain, on your map turn, as a free action. No card, no move, no gold. You must hold at least one unit on that terrain. Announce it, work out its strength **S**, resolve it. That terrain is then spent for the rest of the game — four awakenings in total, and no more.

Strength is counted in tiles' worth of people, not in bodies. Divide your units on that terrain by the number below and round down, minimum 1.

	PLAINS	FOREST	MOUNTAIN	OCEAN
population limit	3	2	1	1
units per point of S	**3**	**2**	**2**	**1**

Three of the four are simply the terrain's own population limit: one point per full tile's worth. Mountain is the exception — two tiles to the point — because mountains are held in numbers rather than in depth. See the notes.

Mountain — Muster. Remove **S** rival units from tiles touching your Mountains. Settle each tile you empty, if you have a unit in reserve.

Forest — Study. Make **S** researches this turn, paying no gold and retiring nothing, with your rank cap raised by **S** for those purchases.

Plains — Harvest. Place **S** units from your reserve onto tiles you already occupy that have room.

Ocean — Expedition. Lay **S** new tiles of any terrain, each touching water you occupy, and put one unit on one of them. Touch-two still applies: Blink has no bridges, and a voyage does not get to build one.

Tighter variant — one awakening a game. Instead of one per terrain, each player gets a single awakening for the whole game and chooses which terrain it comes from. Four one-shots per player over thirteen rounds is a lot of swing at a four-player table; one is a decision you remember.

DESIGNER'S NOTES — WHERE THE NUMBERS COME FROM

The powers themselves are **untested**. What has been measured is the thing the scale rests on: how much of each terrain a player actually holds. Sixty three-player games, base rules, peak holdings over the whole game.

	PLAINS	FOREST	MOUNTAIN	OCEAN
units held (peak)	6.3	5.0	4.4	2.2
tiles held	2.4	2.6	4.3	1.7
units per occupied tile	2.6	1.9	1.0	1.0
resulting S	**2.1**	**2.5**	**2.2**	**2.2**

Counting bodies would have been wrong. Plains hold three to a tile and are filled nearly to the brim; Ocean holds one and is barely used. A flat per-unit scale makes the Plains power three times the Ocean one. Dividing by the population limit lines three of the four up almost exactly — 2.1, 2.5, 2.2 — which is the whole reason the limits belong in the scale.

Mountain is the one that does not fall out of the arithmetic. Its limit is 1, so dividing by it leaves S at 4.4 — twice everything else. Not because mountains are generous but because players hold *many* mountain tiles: 4.3 of them, against 2.4 plains, while having fewer units on them. Two tiles to the point brings it back to 2.2. It is a calibration, not a derivation, and it is printed rather than hidden.

This gives Plains a reason to exist that the base game does not. Because a plains tile holds three, you need very few of them — 2.4 on average — and dominance is scored on your biggest connected *stretch*, counted in tiles. So plains are doubly discouraged as a presence on the map: efficient to stack, worthless to spread. Harvest is the one thing in Blink that pays for depth rather than breadth.

Twenty units across four terrains is the balance. Nobody gets four powers at full strength. Concentrating gives you one large awakening and a dominance score; spreading gives you four modest ones. That the choice is forced by the unit supply, rather than by a rule, is the part worth keeping.

What to watch for. It double-dips: dominance already pays for massing on a terrain, and these pay again on the same count, in a game where the leader already finishes 15 to 19 points clear. Expedition is the one to suspect — map size feeds everything downstream. And Study taking cards for nothing may distort the victory row, which is also points.

Open questions. Should an awakening spend the units — exhaust them, or return one to the reserve? That is the cleanest brake if the double-dip proves real. Should it be once per terrain or once per game? Is Expedition simply the best of the four, whatever the numbers say?